



Mafia

Goes ahead and makes our day

You know the story. The Great Depression, hand-to-mouth existence. Along comes an offer you can't refuse and of course, you don't. So what if it involves working for the Mafia with a baseball bat in hand and a Colt in your waist pocket? People die everyday, the trick is to ensure that you are not one of them. *Mafia* excels in bringing a coherent and intriguing narrative of Tommy Angelo: a taxi driver's rise to fame and fortune, though gory.

Set in the late 1930s and played through a series of flashbacks, the game is set in the believable city of Lost Heaven—lost between the violent acts of rival mob bosses, Salieri and Morelli. Lost Heaven also plays host to a living ecosystem of cars, rival gangs, petty thugs and a bought police force. Chalking your meteoric rise to the ranks of the respected are some 60 authentic cars that you can drive and shelter in Salieri's backyard—the den you call home.



KILLROY WAS HERE: And he left his mark

Missions range from playing the cab driver and ferrying passengers, collecting protection money, assassinating, getting out of hairy shootouts and taking part in a vintage car-race. The experience offered by the variety of missions is always intriguing: forcing you to retry a scenario 'just once more', even though the process involved can be a drag. This is due largely to scripted

events—a certain party will rise from the dead to shoot you just because it was so programmed. A car will burn rubber at more than 60 kmph even though you have shot all of its four wheels, since the mission calls for a car chase. This leaves little room for improvisation and imparts a feeling of being led around the game by its designers. Two more negatives remove from an enjoyable experience—cops will stop and fine you for running red lights and speeding with irritating regularity and fellow gang members (not too bright, god bless them) will frequently walk into a shower of bullets and promptly die of too many holes.

But these issues are just passing clouds under the fresh canopy of blue and light that *Mafia* brings to the PC. In the end the game draws from its superlative narrative, surpasses its flaws and comes out as triumphantly fun, captivating, and a must-play experience.

Genre: Action ■ **Developer:** Illusion Softworks ■ **Distributor:** e-xpress Interactive Software Pvt Ltd ■ **Phone:** 022-28870017
Web site: www.mafia-game.com ■ **Price:** Rs 999 ■ **System requirements:** Pentium 500 MHz, 128 MB RAM, 16 MB T&L AGP/PCI video card
Rating: ★★★★★



Firewall Systems

More than meets the eye

'A firewall system is more than just a product', so goes the title of Chapter 11. This line holds particular relevance for the general masses who tend to think of firewalls as a one-stop security solution against intrusions, viruses and what-have-you.

Firewall Systems is a thorough book. It begins with a chapter explaining why IT security is imperative and how firewalls help. This is quite important to understand where exactly a firewall reaches its limitations and needs to be supplemented by other means. 'TCP/IP Technology for Internet and Intranet', an excellent chapter, makes good reading even for those not necessarily interested in the nitty gritty of firewalls. It covers TCP/IP architecture, addressing, routing and common protocols—things anyone in the IT business can

ill-afford to ignore.

The reasonably clued-in will find much familiar material in this book. Chapter 5, 'Elements of a Firewall System' contains information on all common types of firewalls, including packet filters and proxies. The book also explains the applications of different kinds of firewalls and how they can be made to work for various environments. Firewalls are intrinsically tied into TCP/IP and by association, to everything else, including applications. While it would be beyond the scope of a single book to cover all these topics, this one goes some way to bridge the gaps.

The latter half of the book gets quite



technology and process-heavy. Chapter 13, 'Secondary Issues Relating to Firewall Systems' stretches a full 86 pages and covers everything from Loggin, evaluation and certification and auditing to Denial of Service attacks, virus scanners and personal firewalls. The final chapter covers theoretical topics that define the very basis of a firewall system or product. While not an easy read, it

does go on to explain where defects can show up in a system and how.

Firewall Systems is a very complete book, with much theory as well as practical usage. It is, however, not for the faint of heart and should be considered essential reading only if one is serious about enterprise-class firewall implementations.

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Rating: ★★★★★